



Eye for talent: OGQ's timely support for high jumper Nishad Kumar (above) laid the foundation for successes on the international stage, like his bronze at the Tokyo Paralympics.

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Paris 2024, also happens to be the main sponsor of the upcoming World Para Athletics Championships in New Delhi. This is a step in the right direction, Manjusha feels.

"China and the US have a huge number of para-athletes. We still have a long way to go. But with India hosting, it gives us a few extra entries. It helps...you can be there and find out how they (other countries) are training. There are a lot of things you need to ensure before hosting any para championship. There needs to be better accessibility at all stadiums. If that movement starts with this championship, that will be very nice."

Anukool (**above right**) calls this 'movement' the Paralympic revolution and believes we are slowly yet steadily moving towards a more inclusive sporting ecosystem.



"Conversations about para-sports are becoming much more mainstream. **Inclusivity is not just spoken about in boardrooms. It is being discussed when policy matters are being formulated.** So, I definitely see a change in that point of view. I think the performances at the Paralympics have inspired a lot of young para-athletes to take up sport. There's been a positive change."

And with CSR (Corporate Social Responsibility) partners like IndusInd Bank, AT&T India, Hyundai (that sowed the seeds of the *Samarth* initiative to create a more aware and inclusive society for people with disabilities), and Gameskraft stepping in from time to time to strengthen

GoSports' Para Champions programme, there isn't much to worry about.

Kamath (**below**), who will have 13 of his athletes competing at Delhi's Athletics Worlds soon, says:

"The Para Champions programme was started in 2015 in the build-up to the Rio Games. Eventually, three



(Devendra Jhajaria, Deepa Malik, and Varun Bhati) out of the four medallists were from this programme. That was the first systematic foray into promoting para sports. We already had medallists, we had won gold many years ago, but there was very little awareness and certainly very close to zero systematic support. Athletes even had to cover not only their own flights but also their coaches'."

"Now the support we provide is way more sophisticated. A part of it is adapted equipment — making sure the prosthetics fit well. Almost all of this equipment is of American or German make. It is not just about trying to get access to the best wheelchairs or blades; it's also about how you fit them. A lot of work now goes into the science of para sport. There is deep personalisation. For some of these athletes, their economic status is actually very limited. So, we also provide livelihood grants. Some just need monthly support... if they are at the top of their sport, it doesn't mean they're making money off it."

Come September 26, every leap, throw, and stride will carry the silent strength of these supporters, who have managed to throw the doors wide open when the world kept them shut.